

A La Carte

By AL CARTWRIGHT

Sports Editor

CLEARWATER, FLA., MARCH 16. — "IT WOULD BE kind of nice having a second baseman who could be your cleanup hitter."

Eddie Sawyer said this, the understatement of the young and soggy Grapefruit League season, while discussing the Pancho Herrera situation yesterday. He said it slowly as though savoring the words, like a man with a cud of filet mignon. The second-base diet with the Phillies long has been on the hamburger side.



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The Pancho Herrera situation is that this gigantic Cuban of 6 feet, 3 inches and 235 pounds — of which at least 20 aren't required — is being tried out at second. He is a first baseman, and a fine one, who last season topped the International League in batting, home runs, runs batted in, total hits.

But the Phils' leading hitter last year also was a first baseman, and while Sawyer declares that Ed Bouchee could lose his job to Herrera, he thinks it would be kind of nice to have both bats in the lineup. So Herrera right now is the biggest second sacker you ever saw, maybe in history. Even the prehistoric coaches, Paul Waner and Andy Cohen, can't recall any bigger ones. Sawyer said the largest he ever saw was Johnny Hodapp of Cleveland, but he was no Herrera for size.

Cohen, John McGraw's old Jewish hope with the New York Giants, is teaching Pancho the facts of life at second. Herrera has played first, third and the outfield but never the keystone — but he likes it there.

"I like that side of the infield more than third," he says, with the ever-present smile and in Desi Arnaz English. "More action, and I feel more at home. Some plays just like first base. But any place I can get into the game, is all right with me."

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Splendid Physical Specimen

COHEN THINKS HIS HUGE PUPIL CAN DO IT.

"For one thing, he has a natural throwing arm for a second baseman," the new first-base coach said. "When we get some of that weight off, I think you'll see a pretty-fair performer out there. His weakness now is charging and handling a slow-hit ball, but that's where the weight comes in. He's already showed me he can make the double-play pivot, in two games with the B squad and in another against the Pirates."

Herrera and Henry Mason, a Buffalo pitching alumnus, comprise Trainer Frank Wiechec's fat man's class. Their huffing and puffing over special calisthenics in a corner of Jack Russell Stadium is a daily cinch to fracture the rest of the ball players.

Ask Pancho why the weight and he smiles: "Too much black-eyed beans and rice and bananas over the winter." He did play Winter League ball in Cuba, but favored a broken foot suffered the previous winter, and couldn't burn off the beans and bananas fast enough. Down here, his footwork on the bases has proven that he has the injury licked.

Even with the overweight boiler, Herrera is a magnificent physical specimen. Wiechec says Pancho has the finest set of legs he's ever seen on an athlete. The Cuban has the cherubic facial features of Jackie Robinson and the general build of a heavyweight fighter. In fact, he said he did a little boxing as a 13-year-old, but his mother made him quit.

Francisco Juan Herrera is approaching his 26th birthday, and must arrive soon as a big-leaguer. He has had five seasons in the high minors, averaging better than 20 homers a year. Right-handed all the way, he is a quick and sure first baseman and his gifted hands have helped to inspire this experiment at second.

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Trial at Third Possibility

SAWYER DEFINITELY WANTS THE HERRERA SOCK

on his team, and even indicates he might resume a trial on third. They sent Pancho to Buffalo last year to play third, but the bad foot slowed him up so much he had to go back to first. In 1958, Mayo Smith brought Herrera north but after an 0-for-11 batting experience in the majors, Pancho went back to triple-A. He was recalled late in the season, when Sawyer was the manager, and did well, batting over .300.

"But if Pancho doesn't play first, then second is his best spot," Eddie said. "He doesn't make the long throw from third too well. Still, Bouchee can't afford to loaf on first; he has to win the job. Playing Eddie on first and Pancho on second in the games here gives me the chance to watch them both."

"Herrera looks like the best prospect as a fourth-place hitter that we've ever had with the Phillies. Wally Post doesn't like to hit there, and neither he nor Harry Anderson are my type of cleanup men. They're big swingers, and strike out a lot. Herrera gets a piece of the ball more often, and still has that tremendous power."

The manager sounded annoyed that the Herrera-on-trial has to be done in a big-league camp.

"I don't like to be critical," he said, "but our organization is crowded with promising first basemen, and it's time we know if they can play anywhere else. Bouchee, still is a young ball player. Then Herrera at Buffalo, Emery at Des Moines, Hopke at Williamsport all have outstanding backgrounds as hitters. Seems to me somebody should have tried them at other positions long ago. Especially Herrera, who is the only righthander."

Pancho Herrera may have been wasting his time on first, but that's not his fault. People who watched him bomb the International League last year say that the Phillies can't afford to keep him out of the lineup. Just throw him a glove, they say—any glove.